

GUINEA PIG · *CAVIA PORCELLUS*

Keep your guinea pig the right way from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: floor space, diet and vitamin C, health triage, and the routines that keep a guinea pig thriving for its full lifespan.

22 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything. Floor space and vitamin C are the two decisions that matter most, and both are expensive or risky to get wrong the first time. Get the enclosure size right, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16 to buy once.

If your guinea pig is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist & Climate/Space Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 10 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Climate/Space Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily, Weekly, Monthly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 21: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Guinea pig care advice online is inconsistent, especially on floor space and vitamin C. This package reflects current space, diet, and vitamin C standards, cross-checked against veterinary and care sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian experienced with small mammals or exotics. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Cavia porcellus</i>
Adult size	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm); 1.5 to 2.6 lb
Captive lifespan	4 to 8 years typical with consistent care
Origin	Domesticated species; wild ancestors native to the Andes region of South America
Diet type	Herbivore, hay-forward grazer
Floor space minimum	7.5 sq ft (one guinea pig); about 10.5 sq ft for a pair; 12 in minimum height
Handling difficulty	Beginner; social animals that generally do well with gentle, regular handling
Social needs	Herd animal; generally does better paired or grouped than solitary

Cost overview

Monthly ongoing

\$30 to \$50 for pellets for a pair, plus hay, bedding, fresh vegetables, and vitamin C supplementation.

Annual total

Commonly \$400 to \$1,620, with around \$1,200 a year as a typical middle-ground figure, including a \$50 to \$100 annual wellness exam.

BUDGET TOWARD THE HIGHER END

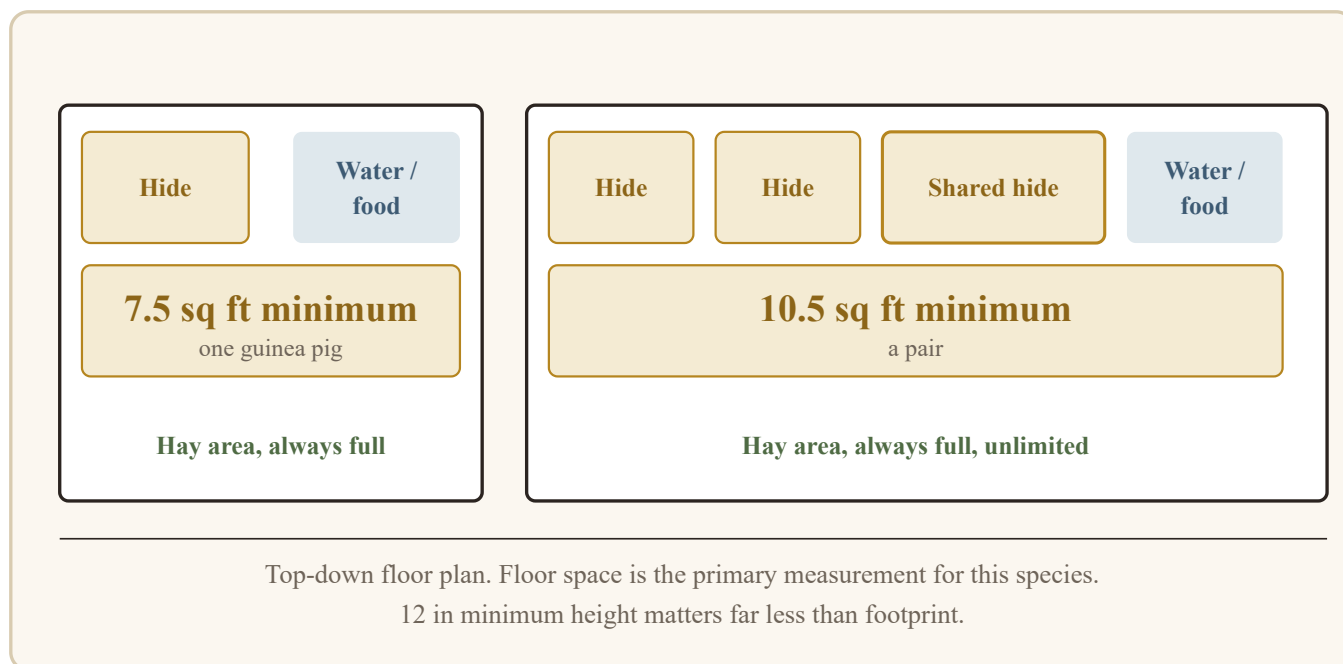
The wide annual range mostly comes down to hay and vet costs. Planning toward the \$1,200 middle-ground figure rather than the \$400 floor avoids surprises.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Guinea pigs aren't pigs and aren't from Guinea. They're rodents, domesticated thousands of years ago from wild caviies native to South America.
- A "wheek," a loud, distinct squeal, is a guinea pig's classic food-anticipation call. Owners often learn to recognize their own guinea pig's version of it.
- As herd animals, guinea pigs communicate constantly through sound and body language, part of why they generally do better with company than alone.

Housing & enclosure

Floor space, not height, is what defines a guinea pig enclosure. A single guinea pig needs a minimum of 7.5 sq ft of usable floor space; a pair needs roughly 10.5 sq ft. Height matters far less for this species: 12 in is the minimum, and going taller doesn't make up for a small footprint. Many owners build a C&C-style grid enclosure or use a commercial cage sized to these minimums; either works as long as the floor space clears the bar.



NEVER

Use cedar or raw (non-kiln-dried) pine shavings as bedding. Both release oils that can irritate a guinea pig's respiratory system. Paper-based bedding, fleece, and kiln-dried pine are all fine.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Give each guinea pig its own hide, plus one larger shared hide if housing a pair, so no one has to choose between hiding and easy access to food and hay.
- Keep the hay area separate from the water and food zone. Hay should be available at all times, and keeping it away from spills keeps it from getting soiled.
- Bigger than the minimum is genuinely better here. 7.5 and 10.5 sq ft are floors, not targets to aim for.

Temperature & climate

ZONE	TARGET
Room / enclosure temperature	Keep below roughly 80°F
Heat stroke risk	Rises quickly once temperatures climb above about 80°F
Cold tolerance	Considerably better than heat tolerance; cold is the smaller concern for this species

This is a ceiling, not a range. Guinea pigs handle cold far better than heat, so the number that matters most is the upper limit, not a lower one.

No heat lamp or UVB required

Unlike some reptiles, guinea pigs don't need supplemental heating, UVB, or specialized lighting to stay healthy. Ordinary indoor room temperature, kept below roughly 80°F, is the target. Put your setup budget toward floor space and vitamin C instead.

Placement matters

Keep the enclosure out of direct sun and away from heating vents or drafty windows. Good airflow around the enclosure helps prevent heat from building up in one spot.

Watch for heat stress

Labored breathing, drooling, and lethargy are all warning signs, whatever the cause. Any of them warrants prompt attention; see page 10.

SIMPLE RULE OF THUMB

If a room is comfortable for a person in a sweater, it's very likely too warm for a guinea pig once it climbs past about 80°F. When in doubt, move the enclosure to the coolest reasonable spot in the home.

Diet & feeding

Guinea pigs are herbivores, and hay is the foundation of the diet, not a side item.

FOOD	SHARE / AMOUNT	FREQUENCY
Hay (grass hay)	Roughly 70 to 80% of intake	Always available, unlimited
Pellets	About 1/8 cup per guinea pig	Daily
Fresh vegetables	Part of daily diet	Daily
Vitamin C (diet and/or supplement)	10 to 50 mg	Daily target

NEVER / AVOID

Alfalfa hay for adults (too high in calcium; fine for very young guinea pigs), iceberg lettuce (no real nutritional value), and high-sugar fruit as anything more than an occasional treat.

Vitamin C is the single most important nutritional fact

Guinea pigs can't produce their own vitamin C. Without enough of it in the diet, deficiency (scurvy, page 11) follows. Target 10 to 50 mg per day through a combination of vitamin C rich vegetables and, if needed, a dedicated supplement such as a chewable tablet or drops. Check any supplement's freshness or expiration date regularly rather than assuming it still works at full strength; log this in the Equipment Log on page 20.

HAY FIRST, ALWAYS

Unlimited hay isn't optional or a nice extra. At 70 to 80% of intake, it's the single largest part of the diet, and it's what keeps teeth worn down properly. See Dental Disease on page 11.

Handling & social needs

Handling

Guinea pigs are prey animals and startle easily, especially from sudden movement or being approached from directly above. Let a new guinea pig settle for several days before handling beyond feeding and cleaning. Always support the full body, including the hindquarters, rather than lifting under the front legs alone, and keep early sessions short and low to the ground in case of a jump or wriggle.

BUILDING TRUST

Short, frequent, low-pressure sessions build confidence faster than occasional long ones. Talking quietly and offering a small piece of vegetable before picking a guinea pig up helps it associate handling with something good rather than something to escape.

Social needs

Guinea pigs are herd animals. As a rule, they generally do better paired or grouped than kept solitary. If keeping a single guinea pig, plan on extra daily interaction to help make up for the lack of a companion. It doesn't fully replace one, but it helps.

CONSIDER A COMPANION

A same-sex pair or a spayed/neutered pair, introduced carefully and gradually, is generally the easiest path to a stable social group. Never assume two unfamiliar guinea pigs can simply be placed together without a supervised introduction.

First days in a new home

A rough timeline: days 1 to 3, hands-off except feeding and spot-cleaning, so your guinea pig can learn the sounds and smells of its new space; days 4 to 7, brief calm presence near the enclosure; week 2 onward, first short handling attempts if eating and behavior look normal.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Treating 7.5 sq ft (or 10.5 for a pair) as a target instead of a bare minimum. Bigger is genuinely better for this species.
- Assuming a taller enclosure makes up for a small footprint. Floor space, not height, is what guinea pigs actually use.
- Using cedar or raw pine shavings, when paper-based bedding, fleece, or kiln-dried pine are all safe and available.
- Assuming pellets alone cover the 10 to 50 mg daily vitamin C target without checking labels or adding fresh sources.
- Feeding alfalfa hay to an adult long-term instead of grass hay.
- Letting the hay supply run low between refills, when it should make up 70 to 80% of intake and be available at all times.
- Keeping a guinea pig fully solo with no plan for company, when the species is a herd animal that generally does better paired or grouped.
- Assuming a warm room is fine because it's "just a bit warm." Heat stroke risk rises quickly once temperatures climb above roughly 80°F.

Enrichment, by priority

Hides & tunnels

Multiple hides and tunnels let a guinea pig feel secure while still moving freely around its floor space.

Foraging

Scattering hay piles or fresh vegetables in a few spots encourages the natural grazing behavior guinea pigs would show in the wild.

Companionship

Paired or grouped housing, where possible, is the single biggest enrichment upgrade for a herd animal.

Chew items & routine

Safe chew toys support natural tooth wear (page 11), and a consistent daily feeding routine doubles as a stress-lowering constant.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Refusal to eat, drooling, labored breathing, diarrhea, lethargy, or a hunched posture. All of these warrant immediate vet care, not a wait-and-see approach.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Recent hay, pellet, and vegetable intake
- ☐ Recent weight trend from the Owner Log (page 20)
- ☐ When symptoms started, and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Whether housed alone or with others, and any recent changes

Why hay and vitamin C come up first

Two of the four conditions in this section trace directly back to two things covered earlier in this package: hay and chewing (dental disease, page 11) and vitamin C (scurvy, page 11). A vet will usually ask about both before anything else, for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Eating a full portion at a normal, steady pace	Refusing food, or drooling and dropping food while trying to eat (page 11)
Calm, quiet breathing at rest	Labored breathing or discharge (page 12)
Regular droppings throughout the day	Reduced or absent droppings, paired with a hunched posture (page 12)
Normal, unremarkable urination	Straining, vocalizing, or blood while urinating (page 13)

Vitamin C deficiency & dental disease

Vitamin C Deficiency (Scurvy)

What it is: guinea pigs can't produce their own vitamin C, so a diet or supplement routine that falls short of the 10 to 50 mg daily target (page 7) can lead to deficiency over time. **Signs:** lethargy, joint pain, a rough coat, and poor wound healing. **Response:** vet-guided vitamin C supplementation alongside a diet correction, not just adding more of whatever isn't working. **Recovery:** generally improves once adequate vitamin C intake is restored; a vet should also check for and treat any secondary issues, like slow-healing wounds, that developed along the way.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

Hitting the 10 to 50 mg daily vitamin C target consistently (page 7) prevents nearly all scurvy cases. It's the single highest-leverage nutritional habit in this whole package.

Dental Disease

Cause: overgrown teeth from insufficient hay intake or chewing. Guinea pig teeth grow continuously, and hay is what wears them down. **Signs:** drooling, weight loss, and dropping food while trying to eat. **Response:** a vet dental check and correction. This isn't something to manage at home once it's underway.

CONCRETE SIGNAL

Drooling combined with dropping food or reduced eating is a dental-disease pattern until a vet rules it out. Don't wait to see if appetite "comes back on its own."

GI stasis & respiratory infections

GI Stasis

What it is: the gut slowing down or stopping. This is a real emergency, not something to monitor overnight.

Signs: reduced or absent droppings, a hunched posture, and refusal to eat. **Response:** immediate vet visit.

Don't wait for it to resolve on its own; a stalled gut can decline quickly.

TREAT THIS AS URGENT

Reduced or absent droppings combined with a hunched posture or loss of appetite means a vet visit now, not later today or tomorrow. GI stasis is one of the fastest-moving problems in this package.

Respiratory Infections

Signs: labored breathing, discharge, and lethargy. **Response:** a prompt vet visit; antibiotics are the typical treatment once a vet confirms it.

DON'T WAIT IT OUT

Labored breathing or discharge is never a "give it a few days" situation for a guinea pig. Both conditions on this page move quickly, and both respond far better to early treatment than late treatment.

Bladder stones & ovarian cysts

Bladder Stones (Urolithiasis)

Signs: straining to urinate, blood in the urine, and vocalizing while urinating. Any one of these is worth a same-week vet visit; all three together warrant going sooner. **Response:** vet diagnosis, which sometimes leads to surgical removal depending on stone size and location.

Ovarian Cysts

Who this affects: intact (unspayed) females only. **Signs:** hair loss along the flanks and behavior changes.

Response: a vet exam, which sometimes leads to a spay depending on findings.

BOTH ARE A "SEE THE VET" SITUATION

Neither condition on this page is something to diagnose or manage at home. Straining to urinate, blood in urine, unusual vocalizing, or flank hair loss with behavior changes in an intact female are all reasons to book a vet visit.

IF YOU'RE NOT PLANNING TO BREED

Ask a vet about the tradeoffs of spaying an intact female. It's a bigger decision than a routine checkup, but it's worth an informed conversation rather than defaulting to "wait and see."

Setup checklist & climate/space targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Enclosure at 7.5 sq ft minimum floor space (10.5 sq ft for a pair)
- ☐ 12 in minimum height
- ☐ One hide per guinea pig, plus a shared hide for pairs
- ☐ Hay area kept separate from food and water
- ☐ Water bottle or bowl
- ☐ Pellet dish
- ☐ Paper-based, fleece, or kiln-dried pine bedding
- ☐ Vitamin C source: vegetables and/or a supplement
- ☐ Grass hay supplier lined up (not alfalfa, for adults)
- ☐ Vitamin C supplement freshness date tracked

Climate & space targets

TARGET	RANGE
Floor space (one guinea pig)	7.5 sq ft minimum
Floor space (a pair)	About 10.5 sq ft minimum
Enclosure height	12 in minimum
Temperature ceiling	Keep below roughly 80°F
Vitamin C	10 to 50 mg daily
Hay	70 to 80% of intake, unlimited

Before your guinea pig comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up before day one
- ☐ Floor space measured and confirmed against the minimums, not estimated by eye
- ☐ Hay and vitamin C source lined up
- ☐ A vet with small-mammal experience identified in advance

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A VET NOW IF

No or greatly reduced droppings · straining, vocalizing, or blood while urinating · labored breathing · refusal to eat · drooling · persistent diarrhea · lethargy or a hunched posture

READING	TARGET
Floor space (one / a pair)	7.5 sq ft / about 10.5 sq ft minimum
Enclosure height	12 in minimum
Temperature ceiling	Keep below roughly 80°F
Vitamin C	10 to 50 mg daily
Hay	70 to 80% of intake, unlimited
Pellets	About 1/8 cup per guinea pig, daily

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Recent hay/food intake, weight trend, when symptoms started, and whether housed alone or with others.

Budget & shopping list

Ongoing costs

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Pellets for a pair (monthly)	\$30 to \$50
Annual wellness exam	\$50 to \$100
Typical annual total (routine care)	\$400 to \$1,620
Common middle-ground figure	About \$1,200/year

BUDGET REALISTICALLY

The wide annual range mostly reflects hay quality and vet-visit variation. Planning toward the \$1,200 middle-ground figure, not the \$400 floor, avoids surprises.

Shopping list

- ☐ Enclosure sized to floor-space minimums (C&C grid or commercial cage)
- ☐ Hides: one per guinea pig, plus a shared hide for pairs
- ☐ Hay rack or designated hay area
- ☐ Water bottle or bowl
- ☐ Pellet dish
- ☐ Paper-based, fleece, or kiln-dried pine bedding
- ☐ Vitamin C supplement (chewable or drops)
- ☐ Grooming brush and nail clippers

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Floor space and vitamin C are the two line items most directly tied to the health conditions in this package. An undersized enclosure and inconsistent vitamin C intake cause more problems than any other single mistake. Save on decor and extras before you save here.

First 30 days, and days 31 to 90

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm floor space and temperature against the targets on page 14, not by estimate
- ☐ Let your guinea pig settle: minimal handling, focus on feeding and observing appetite
- ☐ Schedule a wellness vet visit within the first two weeks

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short, gentle handling sessions if appetite and behavior look normal
- ☐ Establish a consistent hay, pellet, vegetable, and vitamin C routine
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20

Week 4

- ☐ Review weight, appetite, and droppings trends from the Owner Log
- ☐ Check your vitamin C supplement's freshness or expiration date
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the follow-up wellness visit most vets recommend after initial setup
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or droppings
- ☐ If housed solo, consider whether a companion makes sense; guinea pigs generally do better paired or grouped
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Drooling, dropping food, weight loss	Dental disease	Vet dental check (page 11)
Lethargy, joint pain, rough coat	Vitamin C deficiency (scurvy)	Vet + correct vitamin C intake (page 11)
Reduced or absent droppings, hunched posture	GI stasis, an emergency	Vet immediately (page 12)
Labored breathing, discharge	Respiratory infection	Vet promptly, antibiotics (page 12)
Straining, vocalizing, or blood while urinating	Bladder stones	Vet diagnosis (page 13)
Flank hair loss, behavior changes (intact female)	Possible ovarian cysts	Vet exam (page 13)
Persistent diarrhea	Diet, parasites, or stress	Vet visit
Refusal to eat	Several possible causes	Vet promptly (pages 11 to 13)
Sudden weight change between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 20)

Daily, weekly, monthly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Refill hay so it's never empty
- ☐ Feed pellets and fresh vegetables per the schedule on page 7
- ☐ Refresh water and confirm the bottle or bowl is working
- ☐ Quick visual health check: eyes, breathing, posture, appetite, droppings

Weekly

- ☐ Spot-clean bedding
- ☐ Weigh and log in the Owner Log
- ☐ Check water bottle for clogs or leaks (Equipment Log, page 20)
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one enrichment item

Monthly

- ☐ Full bedding change and enclosure deep clean
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Check vitamin C supplement freshness or expiration date

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter
- ☐ In warm months, watch more closely for the 80°F ceiling; guinea pigs handle cold far better than heat

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	APPETITE	DROPPINGS	ACTIVITY	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady weight trend, plus normal appetite and droppings, is the best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up in one of these three before anything else is visible.

Equipment log

ITEM	CHECKED / CHANGED	NEXT CHECK
Water bottle (clogs, leaks)		
Vitamin C supplement freshness		
Bedding change		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ One hide per guinea pig, plus a shared hide for pairs
- ☐ Tunnels or hideaways placed around the floor space
- ☐ Safe chew items to support natural tooth wear

Monthly review

- ☐ Rotate or reposition one item to refresh the layout
- ☐ Offer scatter-fed hay or vegetables, or supervised floor time, at least once
- ☐ Reassess whether a solo guinea pig's social needs are being met

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Scurvy	Vitamin C deficiency disease; guinea pigs can't produce their own vitamin C and need it from diet or supplements.
GI Stasis	A slowing or stopping of the digestive tract; a real emergency requiring an immediate vet visit.
Urolithiasis	The medical term for bladder stones.
Herd animal	A species that lives naturally in groups; guinea pigs generally do better paired or grouped than solitary.
Floor space	Usable enclosure square footage at ground level; the primary housing measurement for guinea pigs.
Kiln-dried pine	Pine bedding heat-treated to remove the aromatic oils raw pine and cedar release; a safe bedding option.
Vitamin C	An essential nutrient guinea pigs cannot produce on their own; target 10 to 50 mg daily through diet or supplementation.
Wellness exam	A routine veterinary checkup, not tied to a specific illness; recommended annually.
Ovarian cyst	A fluid-filled growth on the ovary that can occur in intact (unspayed) females.

Compiled from veterinary and care sources, cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a veterinarian experienced with small mammals, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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